

LET ME TRY · FREE PRINTABLE

What's Behind the 'Naughty' Behaviour?

Common toddler behaviours decoded · Ages 2–4

Most behaviour we call 'naughty' at this age is a child learning about their body, the world and their own will. Understanding why helps us respond calmly.

Climbing

- ○ Why: building strength, balance and confidence
- ○ Try: a safe climbing spot (cushions, a low climber); 'Feet on the floor; you can climb here.'

Throwing

- ○ Why: exploring cause and effect
- ○ Try: soft balls to throw outside; at meals, calmly: 'Food stays on the table. Are you finished?'

Saying no

- ○ Why: discovering independence
- ○ Try: two choices, fewer commands; 'Red cup or blue cup?'

Not listening

- ○ Why: deep concentration, or too many instructions
- ○ Try: get close, make eye contact, one short instruction

Biting and hitting

- ○ Why: big feelings, few words
- ○ Try: 'I won't let you bite.' Teach words: 'Say stop!'

Learn more

The CDC's 'Learn the Signs. Act Early.' milestones show what's typical at each age.

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

CDC: Learn the Signs. Act Early. (developmental milestones). · https://www.cdc.gov/ncbddd/actearly/milestones/

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